

A Packing of 51 Planes in $\mathbb{R}^{13}$

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Abstract

We give 51 2-dimensional subspaces of $\mathbb{R}^{13}$ whose smallest squared chordal distance is at least 1.718864. This cell of the table of best Grassmannian packings has no published value. The best value implied by known packings is 1.716198, obtained by deleting 1 of the 52 planes of the packing listed in Sloane’s 1997 table. The value is checked with exact rational arithmetic from integer coordinates. We do not claim it is optimal.

1 Result

Theorem. *There are 51 subspaces of dimension 2 in $\mathbb{R}^{13}$ whose pairwise squared chordal distances $D(a, b) = 2 - \text{tr}(P_a P_b)$ are all at least*

$$D_{\min} = 1.718864\dots$$

The exact value of $D_{\min}$, a rational number, is given in Appendix A.

2 Context

N. J. A. Sloane’s *Table of Best Grassmannian Packings* (last modified 1997), now maintained by Henry Cohn, lists values for some N in the row $m = 13$, $n = 2$. The cell $N = 51$ is blank in Sloane’s table, in Sloane’s coordinate files and in Cohn’s table as checked on October 8, 2026. The best value implied by known packings is 1.716198, obtained by deleting 1 of the 52 planes of the packing listed in Sloane’s 1997 table. The Rankin simplex bound for this cell is $2(13 - 2)/13 \cdot 51/50 = 1.726154$, and the value above lies below it.

3 Verification

Each subspace is given by an integer $m \times n$ basis Y (coordinates times 10^{12} , rounded). With $G = Y^\top Y$ the projection is $P = YG^{-1}Y^\top$, so for two subspaces

$$\text{tr}(P_a P_b) = \frac{\text{tr}(\text{adj}(G_a) A \text{adj}(G_b) A^\top)}{\det G_a \det G_b}, \quad A = Y_a^\top Y_b,$$

an exact rational number. No orthonormality is assumed and no floating point is used. Run

`python grassmann/verify.py grassmann/packings/m13n2N51.txt`

in <https://github.com/Ge-limin/math719>.

*Found and checked by Claude, a model released by Anthropic, running on the author’s laptop. The author sent the prompts.

4 How it was found

Many random starts of gradient descent on the Grassmannian against a log-sum-exp of the pairwise overlaps, sharpened over time, then a polishing stage (`grassmann/solve.py`); about 99 seconds on one laptop, with about ten such searches running at once.

A Exact value

```

numerator:
429716017724948485061003044223068991304782126654932900457768571944757157
306014855889268324259347
denominator:
249999999999650738590318358874398993720240306042104530050304061839975164
979907414331386452216366

```

B Coordinates

51 blocks of 13 rows with 2 integers each; divide by 10^{12} . File: `grassmann/packings/m13n2N51.txt`.

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